

## Primary Source Reading 2: Two Arguments for the Soul

*Optima Academy Online | Philosophy & Ethics | High School Honors (9–12) From Plato's Phaedo, translated by Benjamin Jowett Read before Lesson 9b: The Cyclical and Recollection Arguments*

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**Before you read:** Socrates has argued that the philosopher should welcome death. Cebes presses him further: that is well and good as an attitude, but does the soul actually survive death? Socrates offers his first argument, built entirely on how opposites behave in nature, and then a second, built on a puzzle about where our knowledge of perfect concepts like equality could possibly come from.

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### The Cyclical Argument: Opposites Generate Each Other

**SOCRATES:** Suppose we consider the question whether the souls of men after death are or are not in the world below. There comes into my mind an ancient doctrine which affirms that they go from hence into the other world, and returning hither, are born again from the dead. (70c)

...One of them I term sleep, the other waking. The state of sleep is opposed to the state of waking, and out of sleeping waking is generated, and out of waking, sleeping. Do you agree?

**CEBES:** I entirely agree.

**SOCRATES:** Then, suppose that you analyze life and death to me in the same manner. Is not death opposed to life?

**CEBES:** Yes.

**SOCRATES:** And they are generated one from the other?

**CEBES:** Yes.

**SOCRATES:** What is generated from the living?

**CEBES:** The dead.

**SOCRATES:** And what from the dead?

**CEBES:** I can only say in answer — the living. (71c–e)

**SOCRATES:** Then the living, whether things or persons, are generated from the dead?

**CEBES:** That is clear.

**SOCRATES:** Then the inference is that our souls exist in the world below?

**CEBES:** That is true.

**SOCRATES:** What then is to be the result? Shall we exclude the opposite process? And shall we suppose nature to walk on one leg only? Must we not rather assign to death some corresponding process of generation?

**CEBES:** Certainly.

**SOCRATES:** And what is that process?

**CEBES:** Return to life.

**SOCRATES:** And return to life, if there be such a thing, is the birth of the dead into the world of the living?

**CEBES:** Quite true.

**SOCRATES:** Then here is a new way by which we arrive at the conclusion that the living come from the dead, just as the dead come from the living; and this, if true, affords a most certain proof that the souls of the dead exist in some place out of which they come again. (72a–d)

*[Cebes and Simmias agree the argument is suggestive. Socrates now turns to a second, independent argument, based on a puzzle about knowledge.]*

### The Recollection Argument: Equality Itself

**SOCRATES:** Shall we affirm that there is such a thing as equality, not of one piece of wood or stone with another, but that, over and above this, there is absolute equality? Shall we say so?

**SIMMIAS:** Say so, yes, and swear to it, with all the confidence in life.

**SOCRATES:** And whence did we obtain our knowledge? Did we not see equalities of material things, such as pieces of wood and stones, and gather from them the idea of an equality which is different from them? ... Do not the same pieces of wood or stone appear at one time equal, and at another time unequal?

**SIMMIAS:** That is certain.

**SOCRATES:** But are real equals ever unequal? or is the idea of equality the same as of inequality?

**SIMMIAS:** Impossible. (74a–c)

**SOCRATES:** But what would you say of equal portions of wood and stone, or other material equals? Are they equals in the same sense in which absolute equality is equal? or do they fall short of this perfect equality in a measure?

**SIMMIAS:** Yes, in a very great measure too.

**SOCRATES:** Then we must have known equality previously to the time when we first saw the material equals, and reflected that all these apparent equals strive to attain absolute equality, but fall short of it?

**SIMMIAS:** Very true.

**SOCRATES:** And did we not see and hear and have the use of our other senses as soon as we were born?

**SIMMIAS:** Certainly.

**SOCRATES:** Then we must have acquired the knowledge of equality at some previous time?

**SIMMIAS:** Yes.

**SOCRATES:** That is to say, before we were born, I suppose?

**SIMMIAS:** True.

**SOCRATES:** And if we acquired this knowledge before we were born, and were born having the use of it, then we also knew before we were born and at the instant of birth not only the equal or the greater or the less, but all other ideas; for we are not speaking only of equality, but of beauty, goodness, justice, holiness, and of all which we stamp with the name of essence. (74d–75d)

### What Has Been Proven, and What Remains

**CEBES:** Very true, Simmias; about half of what was required has been proven; to wit, that our souls existed before we were born: that the soul will exist after death as well as before birth is the other half of which the proof is still wanting, and has to be supplied; when that is given the demonstration will be complete. (77c)

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**After you read:** Cebes puts his finger precisely on what these two arguments have and have not accomplished. The Cyclical Argument suggests souls exist between lives; the Recollection Argument shows the soul knew the Forms before this life began. Neither argument shows that a soul, once it exists, cannot eventually wear out. That is the gap the next argument — the Affinity Argument — will try to close.